HE REJOICES OVER YOU

Small-group kit

Three sessions for home groups and small groups – one per chapter, 75 to 90 minutes each.

SESSION 1	Searched with Lamps	Zephaniah 1:1–18
SESSION 2	Seek the LORD	Zephaniah 2:1–15
SESSION 3	In Your Midst	Zephaniah 3:1–20

Scripture: own translation from the Hebrew (Masoretic Text) by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Verse numbers follow the Hebrew text.
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SESSION 1 · ZEPHANIAH 1:1–18

Searched with Lamps

THE BIG IDEA

The day of the LORD begins at God's own house: his holy, loving light searches the hidden corners of our hearts for divided loyalties and spiritual sluggishness – not because he is a cruel tyrant, but because in the fire of his jealousy he refuses to give his people up to empty idols.

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever opened a cupboard, a fridge or a storeroom that had not been looked at for a long time? What did you find – and how did it get that way?

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

READ TOGETHER · ZEPHANIAH 1:1–18

Use three readers for the three blocks (1:2–6, 1:7–13, 1:14–18); after the words "Silence before the Lord, the LORD!" (1:7) keep half a minute of real silence, and let the third reader take the "day" lines of 1:15–16 slowly, like a bell tolling.

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Zephaniah prophesied in the reign of King Josiah (about 640–609 BC), probably just before Josiah's great reform of 622/621 BC. Judah had just come out of the almost sixty dark years of Manasseh and Amon, who had filled the temple with foreign altars and astrologers. Zephaniah's family line goes back four generations to a Hezekiah – most likely the king – so he probably knew the palace circles from the inside, and his name means "The LORD has hidden". Chapter 1 announces a judgment that reverses creation (1:2–3), strikes Judah and Jerusalem with their divided hearts (1:4–13), and ends with the great "day of the LORD" (1:14–18).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

- ***yom* YHWH** – יוֹם יְהוָה "the day of the LORD": The word "day" tolls through the chapter like a bell – seven times in 1:15–16 alone. The people expected the day of the LORD to be a day when God would destroy their enemies and lift Judah high (compare Amos 5:18); Zephaniah pulls that false security away: the day begins at his own house (compare 1 Peter 4:17). It was fulfilled in the near history when Babylon destroyed Jerusalem in 586 BC, and will be fulfilled finally at Christ's return.
- ***'evrah*** – עֶבְרָה "rage": "A day of rage is that day" (1:15). 'Evrah is anger that overflows and bursts its banks. In the Latin Bible the verse begins Dies irae, dies illa – "Day of wrath, that day" – and from it came the medieval hymn Dies irae, sung for centuries in the Requiem Mass and set to music by Mozart and Verdi.
- ***haqqof'im 'al-shimreihem*** – הַקֹּפְאִים עַל שִׁמְרֵיהֶם "who have thickened on their dregs": A picture from winemaking (1:12; compare Jeremiah 48:11). Wine was left on its lees for a time to gain strength, but at the right time it had to be poured off; left too long, it turned thick, syrupy and useless. So these comfortable, prosperous people had become spiritually lazy.

DISCUSSION

1. In Genesis 1 God creates fish and birds, then animals, and finally human beings. Zephaniah reverses the order: "I will sweep away man and beast; I will sweep away the birds of the heavens and the fish of the sea". What does this say about sin – is it ever just a private matter? (Zephaniah 1:2–3)
2. God speaks of "those who bow down and swear to the LORD and swear by their king" – the people still had the LORD's name on their lips, while looking for security to another "king" (probably the idol Milkom). What are the "Milkoms" of our culture – the things we bow before while still confessing the Lord? (Zephaniah 1:4–6)
3. "Silence before the Lord, the LORD!" The people thought the day of the LORD would be good news for them and bad news for their enemies. Why is it uncomfortable to hear that God's judgment begins at his own house? What helps us to be still before him rather than defend ourselves? (Zephaniah 1:7)
4. "At that time I will search Jerusalem with lamps". Wine left too long on its dregs turns thick and useless. Where can comfort, routine or disappointment make us spiritually sluggish – thick, self-satisfied and asleep? (Zephaniah 1:12)
5. They say in their heart: "The LORD does no good, and he does no evil." They did not deny that God exists, only that he is involved. In which areas of the week (work, money, social media, our thought life) do we easily live as if they lay outside his field of vision? (Zephaniah 1:12–13)
6. "Neither their silver nor their gold will be able to rescue them" – said to a city with a trading quarter where merchants weighed out silver (1:11). What do we expect to protect us when things go wrong? How does the chapter answer that? (Zephaniah 1:18)
7. Day 1 reads "the fire of his jealousy" as the zeal of a loving covenant God who will not give his children up, and says that the day of rage and darkness was poured out in full on Jesus at Golgotha. How does that change the way you hear this chapter? And if the Lord walked with a lamp through the hidden rooms of your heart, what might he find standing beside your worship of him? Share only what you are comfortable sharing. (Zephaniah 1:14–18)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Begin each day this week with two minutes of silence before God (1:7). Then ask him to shine his lamp on one area of your life – your diary, your bank statement, your phone – and listen to what he shows you.
- Name one "Milkom" you are tempted to trust for your security (money, status, approval, control). Take one concrete step this week that shows where your trust really lies – give something away, tell someone, or hand a worry to God in prayer each time it comes back.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a minute of shared silence, as 1:7 calls for. Then let each one, quietly or aloud, ask God to search his or her heart and to forgive a divided heart. Thank Jesus together that he bore the darkness and rage of the day of judgment at Golgotha, so that we can be hidden and safe in him. Close by asking him for an undivided heart that fears and serves him alone.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This first session opens the series. Take two minutes to introduce Zephaniah: his name means "The LORD has hidden", and his three short chapters move from the dark day of the LORD (1:2) to one of the tenderest promises in the Old Testament, "he rejoices over you with a song of joy" (3:17), which gives the series its title. Tell the group that the light comes, but not tonight.
- This is a chapter of judgment from start to finish, and some will find it hard to hear. Don't skip or soften it, and don't rush to comfort before the text has spoken. Follow day 1: God searches with lamps not as a cruel tyrant but as a jealous, loving covenant God who refuses to give his children up to idols and spiritual death; and in Christ the day of rage was borne at Golgotha. Make sure the evening ends with that hope, not in gloom.
- Some people carry memories of harsh, fear-driven preaching or of an angry father, and texts like 1:15–18 can reopen those wounds. Listen without arguing, keep the personal questions voluntary, and offer a conversation afterwards.
- Questions about the end of the world can take over the evening. Keep to day 1's two horizons – fulfilled in 586 BC, finally fulfilled at Christ's return – and steer back to the heart question of verses 5 and 12.
- Details such as "their king" (malkam, possibly the idol Milkom), the Fish Gate and the Mortar (probably a trading quarter) can be explained in a sentence; there is no need to locate them.
- Question 7 is searching. Give a moment of silence before anyone answers, and let "nothing to share" be a fine answer.

Related devotionals: Day 1 – The Light That Searches the Shadows of the Heart

Zephaniah 1:1–18

1 The word of the LORD that came to Zephaniah
son of Cushi, son of Gedaliah, son of Amariah,
son of Hezekiah, in the days of Josiah son of
Amon, king of Judah.

2 I will sweep away, sweep away everything
from the face of the ground –
declares the LORD.
3 I will sweep away man and beast;
I will sweep away the birds of the heavens
and the fish of the sea,
and the stumbling blocks with the wicked.
I will cut off mankind
from the face of the ground –
declares the LORD.
4 I will stretch out my hand against Judah
and against all the inhabitants of Jerusalem.
I will cut off from this place the remnant of
Baal,
the name of the idol-priests together with the
priests,
5 and those who bow down on the rooftops
to the host of the heavens,
and those who bow down and swear to the LORD
and swear by their king,
6 and those who turn back from following the
LORD,
who have not sought the LORD
and have not inquired of him.
7 Silence before the Lord, the LORD!
For the day of the LORD is near;
for the LORD has prepared a sacrifice,
he has consecrated those he invited.
8 On the day of the LORD's sacrifice
I will punish the officials and the king's sons
and all who clothe themselves in foreign
clothing.
9 And on that day I will punish
everyone who leaps over the threshold,
those who fill the house of their master
with violence and deceit.
10 On that day – declares the LORD –
a cry will sound from the Fish Gate,
wailing from the Second Quarter,
and a great crash from the hills.
11 Wail, you inhabitants of the Mortar!
For all the people of Canaan are destroyed;
all who weigh out silver are cut off.
12 At that time I will search Jerusalem with
lamps,
and I will punish the men
who have thickened on their dregs,
who say in their heart:
"The LORD does no good,
and he does no evil."
13 Their wealth will become plunder
and their houses a desolation.
They will build houses but not live in them;
they will plant vineyards but not drink their
wine.
14 Near is the great day of the LORD,
near and hurrying very fast.
Listen! The day of the LORD!
Bitterly the warrior cries out there.
15 A day of rage is that day,
a day of distress and anguish,
a day of wreck and ruin,
a day of darkness and deep gloom,
a day of cloud and thick darkness,
16 a day of ram's horn and battle cry
against the fortified cities
and against the lofty corner towers.
17 I will bring distress on mankind,
and they will walk like the blind,
for they have sinned against the LORD.
Their blood will be poured out like dust,
and their flesh like dung.
18 Neither their silver nor their gold
will be able to rescue them
on the day of the rage of the LORD.
In the fire of his jealousy
the whole earth will be devoured;
for a full end, yes, a terrifying end
he will make of all the inhabitants of the earth.

SESSION 2 · ZEPHANIAH 2:1–15

Seek the LORD

THE BIG IDEA

God's warnings are a gracious invitation: he calls a numb people to seek him, righteousness and humility while there is time, and he shows that every proud power that says "I am, and there is none besides me" will fall – so our security lies not in high walls but in whom we are hidden.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

TO GET STARTED

As a child, where was your favourite hiding place – and who were you hiding from?

READ TOGETHER · ZEPHANIAH 2:1–15

One person reads the urgent call of 2:1–3; then four readers each take one point of the compass – west (2:4–7), east (2:8–11), south (2:12), north (2:13–15). If you can, draw a simple compass on paper and point to each direction as it is read.

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

After the storm clouds of chapter 1, Zephaniah changes his tone from accusation to an urgent plea: "Seek the LORD" (2:1–3). Then he walks a full circle of the compass around Judah: west to the Philistine coastal cities (2:4–7), east to Moab and Ammon, Israel's relatives through Lot (2:8–11), far south to Cush, the land along the Nile beyond Egypt (2:12), and north to Assyria and its capital Nineveh (2:13–15), which fell in 612 BC and was never rebuilt. The message: the LORD is King over the whole world, and no corner of the earth lies outside his jurisdiction.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

- ***hitqosheshu waqoshu*** – הִתְקוֹשְׁשׁוּ וְקוֹשׁוּ "gather yourselves together, yes, gather": The verb qoshesh is used elsewhere for gathering stubble or straw (Exodus 5:7, 12) – literally something like "gather yourselves up like straw", an idiom for "Pull yourselves together! Come to your senses!" Straight after it comes "like chaff the day passes by" (2:2): the opportunity for grace blows past as fast as chaff in the wind.
- ***tissateru*** – תִּסָּתְרוּ "you will be hidden": "perhaps you will be hidden on the day of the anger of the LORD" (2:3). The verb is satar, "to hide" – a different root from tsafan, from which Zephaniah's name comes ("The LORD has hidden"), but very close in meaning: a quiet play on the prophet's name. The "perhaps" does not make God fickle; it shows how serious the moment is.
- ***ani we'afsi 'od*** – אֲנִי וְאַפְסִי עוֹד "I am, and there is none besides me": Nineveh's motto (2:15) echoes the words with which God describes himself in Isaiah (compare Isaiah 45:5–6: "I am the LORD, and there is no other"); Isaiah 47:8, 10 puts the same words in the mouth of Babylon. Nineveh speaks like one who takes God's place – and ends as a lair for wild beasts.

DISCUSSION

1. Zephaniah calls Judah a "nation without longing". The word can mean a nation that no longer longs for God, or one that no longer turns pale at its own sin. Where do we see in our culture – and in ourselves – a conscience that has grown numb ("everyone does it")? (Zephaniah 2:1–2)

2. “Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land”. Zephaniah tells people who are already humble to “seek humility”. Why is humility a daily choice rather than a certificate on the wall? Which of the three – seeking the LORD, righteousness or humility – is most neglected in your routine at the moment? (Zephaniah 2:3)
3. “perhaps you will be hidden on the day of the anger of the LORD.” How do you hear that “perhaps”? What does it mean for the believer that “your life is hidden with Christ in God” (Colossians 3:3)? (Zephaniah 2:3)
4. The rich harbour cities of Philistia looked unshakeable, yet they become pastures for sheep, and “For the LORD their God will care for them and turn back their captivity.” The verb for “care for” (paqad) is the same one used for “punish” in chapter 1. Which “fortresses” in your life look too big to overcome – and how does it change things to know that the Lord cares for you? (Zephaniah 2:4–7)
5. “I have heard the reproach of Moab and the revilings of the Ammonites”. God takes the mockery of his people personally and swears by his own life (2:9). Where have you been belittled or treated unfairly? What would it mean to lay down the burden of revenge and leave your case in his hands? (Zephaniah 2:8–10)
6. In the middle of the judgment oracles: “and they will bow down to him, each from its place, all the coastlands of the nations.” Long before the New Testament, Zephaniah sees worship spreading to the most distant nations in their own lands (compare John 4:21–24). How does that widen our view of what God is doing in the world? (Zephaniah 2:11)
7. Nineveh said in her heart: “I am, and there is none besides me.” We would never say that in church, but we can live it when our finances, health and career go well. Where might you be living with a quiet “Nineveh attitude” – “I've got this under control; I don't need anyone”? (Zephaniah 2:13–15)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one of the three commands of 2:3 – seek the LORD, seek righteousness, seek humility – and take one concrete step each day this week (for example: ten minutes with God before the phone, putting right a small dishonesty, letting someone else be right).
- Where you have been treated unfairly, write the words “I have heard” (2:8) on a card and hand the matter to God in prayer each time it comes back to mind. Where you recognise a “Nineveh attitude”, ask someone for help with something this week.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God that his warnings come from a heart of rescue. Let each one pray a sentence of confession for a numb or proud heart, and then pray together the three commands of 2:3, asking God to make you a people who seek him, righteousness and humility. Close by praying for those in the group who feel mocked or overwhelmed, and thank the Lord that in Christ they are hidden and cared for.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals (day 2: 2:1–7; day 3: 2:8–15). Spend most of the time on 2:1–3, the heartbeat of the book, and on 2:15; keep the geography light. A compass drawn on paper (west, east, south, north) does more than a list of dates.
- Oracles against other nations can sound like gloating or nationalism. Point out that Judah was judged first (chapter 1), that the charge against the nations is pride and mockery (2:10, 15), and that the goal is worship from every place (2:11). Keep the surprise of 3:1 for next time.
- The question on mockery and injustice can touch real wounds – bullying, a hostile workplace, a family rift, persecution for faith. Don't push anyone to tell their story, and don't turn "I have heard" into a promise of quick revenge; it is an invitation to leave the case with God.
- The "perhaps" of 2:3 may unsettle people who are anxious about their salvation. Follow day 2: it does not mean God is fickle, but that grace is never a cheap right we can claim; in Christ the believer is already safely hidden (Colossians 3:3).
- Some details are uncertain: whether "without longing" means "not longing" or "not turning pale" (2:1), which creatures are meant in 2:14, and what "A voice will sing in the window" refers to. Name the uncertainty in a sentence and move on.
- The Cherethites (2:5) are probably the Philistines, whose ancestors came from Crete; Gath is missing from the four cities, probably because it had already lost its importance.

Related devotionals: Day 2 – Seek the LORD: The Call to Humility and a Place of Shelter · Day 3 – The Downfall of Pride and the Sole Sovereignty of God

Zephaniah 2:1–15

1 Gather yourselves together, yes, gather,
O nation without longing,
2 before the decree is born –
like chaff the day passes by –
before there comes upon you
the burning anger of the LORD,
before there comes upon you
the day of the anger of the LORD.
3 Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land,
who have done his justice.
Seek righteousness, seek humility;
perhaps you will be hidden
on the day of the anger of the LORD.
4 For Gaza will be forsaken,
and Ashkelon a desolation;
Ashdod – at noon they will drive her out,
and Ekron will be uprooted.
5 Woe to the inhabitants of the seacoast,
the nation of the Cherethites!
The word of the LORD is against you,
Canaan, land of the Philistines:
I will make you perish
until there is no inhabitant.
6 The seacoast will become pastures,
meadows for shepherds
and pens for flocks.
7 The coast will belong
to the remnant of the house of Judah;
there they will graze,
in the houses of Ashkelon
they will lie down at evening.
For the LORD their God will care for them
and turn back their captivity.
8 I have heard the reproach of Moab
and the revilings of the Ammonites,
with which they reproached my people
and made themselves great against their
territory.
9 Therefore, as I live –
declares the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel –
Moab will become like Sodom,
and the Ammonites like Gomorrah:
a place possessed by nettles, and a salt pit,
and a desolation for ever.
The remnant of my people will plunder them,
and the rest of my nation will inherit them.
10 This they will have for their pride,
because they reproached and made themselves
great
against the people of the LORD of hosts.
11 Fearsome will the LORD be against them,
for he will make all the gods of the earth waste
away;
and they will bow down to him, each from its
place,
all the coastlands of the nations.
12 You too, Cushites –
they are slain by my sword.
13 And he will stretch out his hand against the
north
and make Assyria perish,
and he will make Nineveh a desolation,
dry as the wilderness.
14 Herds will lie down in her midst,
every beast of a nation;
the desert owl and the hedgehog
will lodge among her capitals.
A voice will sing in the window,
devastation on the doorstep,
for the cedar work is laid bare.
15 This is the exulting city
that sat secure,
that said in her heart:
"I am, and there is none besides me."
How she has become a desolation,
a lair for wild beasts!
Everyone who passes by her
hisses and shakes his fist.

SESSION 3 · ZEPHANIAH 3:1–20

In Your Midst

THE BIG IDEA

God does what we cannot do for ourselves: he exposes our deafness, refines us in the fire of his judgment, gives us a pure lip and a humble heart – and then, with the judgments taken away, the King in our midst, a warrior who saves, rejoices over us with a song of joy.

TO GET STARTED

Think of someone whose face lights up when they see you – a grandparent, a friend, a child, a dog at the door. What does it do to you to be welcomed like that?

READ TOGETHER · ZEPHANIAH 3:1–20

Read 3:1–8 without saying beforehand which city is meant, and let the group discover it. A second reader takes 3:9–13. Then the whole group reads the call to joy in 3:14–16, the leader reads 3:17 slowly over the group, and a third reader closes with 3:18–20.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
35 min	Discussion
20 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 2 Judah would have cheered at Nineveh's downfall. Now Zephaniah pronounces a new "Woe" over a rebellious, defiled, oppressing city without naming it – and only in verses 2 and 4 does it become clear that he means Jerusalem herself (3:1–5). The fire of God's judgment (3:6–8) is not the last word but a furnace that refines: God promises a pure lip for the peoples, a reversal of Babel (3:9–10), and a humble remnant that shelters in his name (3:11–13). The book ends with one of the most tender love songs in Scripture (3:14–20), with 3:17, the verse that gives the series its title.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

- ***musar*** **– מוּסָר** "discipline": "She has not listened to the voice; she has not accepted discipline." (3:2). Musar is loving correction – not punishment meant to destroy, but a father's training (compare Hebrews 12:5–11). Verse 2 traces decline in four steps: not listening, not accepting discipline, not trusting, not drawing near. When we stop listening and push away his correction, trust and prayer dry up.
- ***safah berurah*** **– שָׂפָה בְרוּרָה** "a pure lip": "For then I will change the lip of the peoples into a pure lip" (3:9). Safah means "lip", but also "speech, language". At Babel the whole earth had one safah, and there the LORD confused their safah (Genesis 11:1, 7, 9). Here God reverses Babel: people from every nation, even from beyond the rivers of Cush, will call on his name and serve him "shoulder to shoulder" (shekhem 'echad, literally "with one shoulder", like oxen under one yoke). The New Testament fulfilment begins at Pentecost (Acts 2).
- ***yacharish be'ahavato*** **– יַחֲרִישׁ בְּאַהֲבָתוֹ** "he is silent in his love": The phrase in 3:17 is hard. Literally it says "he is silent (keeps still) in his love", and that is how we translate it; some read "he quiets you by his love", and the Septuagint has "he will renew you". Day 5 pictures a mother who grows still over a crying child in wordless tenderness, and a God who is silent about our former sins and never brings them up again – he has taken away the judgments (3:15).

DISCUSSION

1. The listeners expected another woe on Nineveh – and then heard: "to her God she has not drawn near." Why is it so much easier to see the sins of "out there" than our own spiritual deafness? Of the four steps in verse 2 – listening, accepting discipline, trusting, drawing near – where do you feel the most resistance at the moment? (Zephaniah 3:1–2)

2. Compare verse 5 with verse 7: "Morning by morning he brings his justice to light" – but "they rose early and made all their deeds corrupt." What does the way you begin your mornings – your first thoughts, first loyalty, first energy – show about who is king in your life? (Zephaniah 3:5–7)

3. At Babel God confused humanity's "lip"; here he promises to change it "into a pure lip", so that all "call on the name of the LORD and serve him shoulder to shoulder." What did the words that crossed your lips this past week say about your heart? Where do you need God to give you a pure lip? (Zephaniah 3:9–10)

4. "I will leave in your midst a people poor and lowly, and they will shelter in the name of the LORD." This is not about being downtrodden but about being healed of self-exaltation. Are you building your identity on looking strong and independent – or have you found the freedom of sheltering in his name? (Zephaniah 3:11–13)

5. Watch the words "in her midst" and "in your midst" through the chapter: roaring lions (3:3), the righteous LORD (3:5), the proud removed (3:11), the poor left (3:12), the King (3:15), the warrior who saves (3:17). Why can a city that was under heavy judgment now sing? Look at the two reasons in verse 15: "The LORD has taken away the judgments against you" and "The King of Israel, the LORD, is in your midst". (Zephaniah 3:14–15)

6. Many believers picture God with a frown – loving them because he has to, but always a little disappointed. Verse 17 says: "He beams with gladness over you; he is silent in his love; he rejoices over you with a song of joy." Which of these phrases is hardest for you to believe about yourself? What keeps you from accepting his joy over you? (Zephaniah 3:16–17)

7. God gathers those who grieve far from the feast, saves "the lame" and assembles "the outcast", and makes them "a praise and a name" where they were put to shame (3:18–19). Looking back over the whole book – from "I will sweep away, sweep away everything" (1:2) to "he rejoices over you" (3:17) – what has God shown you in this series? Share only what you are comfortable sharing. (Zephaniah 3:18–20)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, before you check your phone, read 3:17 aloud with your own name in it, and give God your first thought of the day (3:5).
- Think of someone who is "limping" or has fallen behind – far from the church's feasts, discouraged or ashamed. Contact them this week with a message, a visit or an invitation, as a small sign of the God who gathers the lame and the outcast.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with thanks for the whole journey from the dark day of chapter 1 to the song of chapter 3. Let a moment of silence give room to lay down pride and old shame at the foot of the cross. Then let anyone who wishes name, in a sentence, where their hands are hanging limp (3:16), and let the group pray for one another. Close by reading 3:17 aloud together over one another as a blessing.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This last session closes the series. Leave ten minutes at the end to look back from 1:2 to 3:17, the series title – the same God who searches with lamps is the God who sings over his people.
- The session covers two devotionals (day 4: 3:1–13; day 5: 3:14–20), so it is full. If time is short, take 3:6–8 briefly and give the most time to 3:2, 3:9 and 3:17.
- Group members may know other renderings of 3:17 (“he quiets you by his love”, “he will renew you”). Explain in a sentence why our translation keeps the literal “he is silent in his love” (see the word study), and then move on from the translation question to what it says about God's heart.
- For people who have only known God as a distant, disappointed judge, 3:17 can be hard to believe or can bring tears. Give space and silence; don't force anyone to say they feel it. The text speaks of what God does, not of how we feel.
- “Poor and lowly” (3:12) must not be heard as glorifying poverty or saying God wants his children downtrodden. Follow day 4: it is about being healed of self-exaltation and finding security in the name of the LORD.
- The prayer time may need longer than usual. If needed, shorten the context and take the last discussion question into the prayer time.

Related devotionals: Day 4 – From Rebellion to Cleansing: The Birth of a Humble Remnant · Day 5 – The God Who Rejoices over You with a Song of Love

Zephaniah 3:1–20

1 Woe to the rebellious and defiled one,
the oppressing city!
2 She has not listened to the voice;
she has not accepted discipline.
In the LORD she has not trusted;
to her God she has not drawn near.
3 Her officials in her midst
are roaring lions;
her judges are wolves at evening
that leave nothing for the morning.
4 Her prophets are reckless,
men of treachery;
her priests profane what is holy;
they do violence to the instruction.
5 The LORD in her midst is righteous;
he does no injustice.
Morning by morning he brings his justice to light;
it never fails.
But the unjust knows no shame.
6 I have cut off nations;
their corner towers are desolate.
I have laid waste their streets,
with no one passing through.
Their cities lie in ruins,
with no one left, with no inhabitant.
7 I said: "Surely you will fear me,
you will accept discipline" –
then her dwelling would not be cut off,
all that I had appointed for her.
But they rose early
and made all their deeds corrupt.
8 Therefore wait for me – declares the LORD –
for the day when I rise up for plunder.
For my judgment is to gather nations,
to assemble kingdoms,
to pour out on them my fury,
all my burning anger;
for in the fire of my jealousy
the whole earth will be devoured.
9 For then I will change the lip of the peoples
into a pure lip,
so that all of them call on the name of the LORD
and serve him shoulder to shoulder.
10 From beyond the rivers of Cush
my worshippers, the daughter of my dispersed ones,
will bring my offering.
11 On that day you will not be put to shame
for all your deeds
by which you rebelled against me;
for then I will remove from your midst
those who exult in your pride,
and you will no longer be haughty
on my holy mountain.
12 I will leave in your midst
a people poor and lowly,
and they will shelter in the name of the LORD.
13 The remnant of Israel
will do no injustice and speak no lie,
and no deceitful tongue
will be found in their mouth.
For they will graze and lie down,
and no one will make them afraid.
14 Sing for joy, Daughter Zion!
Shout aloud, Israel!
Be glad and exult with all your heart,
Daughter Jerusalem!
15 The LORD has taken away the judgments against you;
he has turned away your enemy.
The King of Israel, the LORD, is in your midst;
you will fear evil no more.
16 On that day it will be said to Jerusalem:
"Do not fear, Zion!
Do not let your hands hang limp!
17 The LORD your God is in your midst,
a warrior who saves.
He beams with gladness over you;
he is silent in his love;
he rejoices over you with a song of joy."
18 Those who grieve far from the appointed feast I have gathered;
they were from you –

a burden on her, a reproach.
19 Look, at that time I will deal
with all who afflict you.
I will save the lame
and assemble the outcast,
and I will make them a praise and a name
in all the earth where they were put to shame.

20 At that time I will bring you home,
at the time when I assemble you;
for I will make you a name and a praise
among all the peoples of the earth,
when I turn back your captivity
before your eyes, says the LORD.